Cautionary Tales for Children

By Hilaire Belloc

INTRODUCTION

Children grow up hearing tales told to them by their parents and grandparents. Often these tales are designed to teach a lesson, caution against disobedience or sometime even terrorize the poor tots into good behavior. Collectively we call these stories Cautionary Tales.

Now I'm not talking about stories like Hansel and Gretel, who use their wits and resourcefulness to not only kill the wicked witch in the house of gingerbread, but also to find their way home and live happily ever after. . . . No, in Cautionary Tales, the children have bad habits, disobey their elders or otherwise make really bad decisions AND they meet a fate that often far exceeds the crime.

Today, you'll hear about 4 lovely children: Henry King, Jim, Charles Augustus Fortescue, and Rebecca . . . All typical children who meet their unfortunate demise in Cautionary Tales for Children by Hilaire Belloc.

Meet Henry King who had the terrible habit of gnawing on non-food items . . .

The Chief Defect of Henry King
Was chewing little bits of String.
At last he swallowed some which tied

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Itself in ugly Knots inside.
Physicians of the Utmost Fame
Were called at once; but when they came
They answered, as they took their Fees,
"There is no Cure for this Disease.
"Henry will very soon be dead."
His Parents stood about his Bed
Lamenting his Untimely Death,
When Henry, with his Latest Breath,
Cried, "Oh, my Friends, be warned by me,
That Breakfast, Dinner, Lunch, and Tea
Are all the Human Frame requires..."
With that, the Wretched Child expires.

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Next there was Jim who had a tendency to wander away from his elders . . .

There was a Boy whose name was Jim;
His Friends were very good to him.
They gave him Tea, and Cakes, and Jam,
And slices of delicious Ham,
And Chocolate with pink inside

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And little Tricycles to ride,
And read him Stories through and through,
And even took him to the Zoo--
But there it was the dreadful Fate
Befell him, which I now relate.
You know--or at least you ought to know,
For I have often told you so--
That Children never are allowed
To leave their Nurses in a Crowd;
Now this was Jim's especial Foible,
He ran away when he was able,
And on this inauspicious day
He slipped his hand and ran away!
He hadn't gone a yard when--Bang!
With open Jaws, a lion sprang,
And hungrily began to eat
The Boy: beginning at his feet.
Now, just imagine how it feels
When first your toes and then your heels,
And then by gradual degrees,
Your shins and ankles, calves and knees,

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Are slowly eaten, bit by bit.
No wonder Jim detested it!
No wonder that he shouted "Hi!"
The Honest Keeper heard his cry,
Though very fat he almost ran
To help the little gentleman.
"Ponto!" he ordered as he came
(For Ponto was the Lion's name),
"Ponto!" he cried, with angry Frown,
"Let go, Sir! Down, Sir! Put it down!"
The Lion made a sudden stop,
He let the Dainty Morsel drop,
And slunk reluctant to his Cage,
Snarling with Disappointed Rage.
But when he bent him over Jim,
The Honest Keeper's Eyes were dim.
The Lion having reached his Head,
The Miserable Boy was dead!
When Nurse informed his Parents, they
Were more Concerned than I can say:--
His Mother, as She dried her eyes,

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Said, "Well--it gives me no surprise,
He would not do as he was told!''
His Father, who was self-controlled,
Bade all the children round attend
To James's miserable end,
And always keep a-hold of Nurse
For fear of finding something worse.

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But, contrary to popular belief, not all misbehaving children are boys

. . . Meet Rebecca Who Slammed Doors For Fun And Perished Miserably

A trick that everyone abhors
In little girls is slamming doors.
A wealthy banker's little daughter
Who lived in Palace Green, Bayswater
(By name Rebecca Offendort),
Was given to this furious sport.
She would deliberately go
And slam the door like billy-o!

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To make her uncle Jacob start.
She was not really bad at heart,
But only rather rude and wild;
She was an aggravating child...
It happened that a marble bust
Of Abraham was standing just
Above the door this little lamb
Had carefully prepared to slam,
And down it came! It knocked her flat!
It laid her out! She looked like that.
Her funeral sermon (which was long
And followed by a sacred song)
Mentioned her virtues, it is true,
But dwelt upon her vices too,
And showed the deadful end of one
Who goes and slams the door for fun.
The children who were brought to hear
The awful tale from far and near
Were much impressed, and idly swore
They never more would slam the door,
-- As often they had done before.

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And occasionally you even find a well-behaved child. I'll leave you on a less macabre note by introducing the benefits of good behavior through Charles Augustus Fortescue . . .

The nicest child I ever knew
Was Charles Augustus Fortescue.
He never lost his cap, or tore
His stockings or his pinafore:
In eating Bread he made no Crumbs,
He was extremely fond of sums,
To which, however, he preferred
The Parsing of a Latin Word--
He sought, when it was within his power,
For information twice an hour,
And as for finding Mutton-Fat
Unappetizing, far from that!
He often, at his Father's Board,
Would beg them, of his own accord,
To give him, if they did not mind,

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The Greasiest Morsels they could find--
His Later Years did not belie
The Promise of his Infancy.
In Public Life he always tried
To take a judgment Broad and Wide;
In Private, none was more than he
Renowned for quiet courtesy.
He rose at once in his Career,
And long before his Fortieth Year
Had wedded Fifi, Only Child
Of Bunyan, First Lord Aberfylde.
He thus became immensely Rich,
And built the Splendid Mansion which
Is called The Cedars, Muswell Hill,
Where he resides in affluence still,
To show what everybody might
Become by **SIMPLY DOING RIGHT**.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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